

# 60 revolutions

WINDS OF CHANGE

## SATELLITE TV

■ By Ashis Ray

**T**he 15-year saga of satellite television in India is, in many respects, one of phenomenal success. Indians can now conceivably access around 200 television channels and an estimated 70 million homes enthusiastically subscribe to cable—making it one of the biggest national markets. However, broadcasters and subscribers alike continue to be cheated by quality-unconscious cable operators. The Central government has also abysmally failed to tailor the exponential growth of the industry, at times even proving to be a hindrance to progress.

For years, the national broadcaster Doordarshan (DD), with a mainly unwatchable channel, was the only electronically-transmitted audio-visual presence. This changed in January 1991 when the US embarked on a bombardment of Baghdad, in retaliation for Iraq's invasion of Kuwait. From the rooftop of a Baghdad hotel, the Atlanta-based Cable News Network (CNN) was able to communicate the spectre of the aerial attack live via satellite to the whole world. As word spread of this channel's coverage, five-star hotels in India allocated rooms, otherwise utilised for banquets, to offer a ring-side view of the action. Under India's archaic laws, the reception of such signals was illegal. But a force of technology was overtaking the nation, with the government frozen in bewilderment as the revolution rumbled on.

Four months later, Rajiv Gandhi was unspeakably blown to smithereens by a suicide bomber. Britain's Independent Television News (ITN), in a world exclusive for electronic media, broke the story. Immediately, CNN, an associate of ITN, began broadcasting hourly updates. Roughly 4,00,000 households in India had satellite or cable connections on the night of the assassination and could keep abreast of developments. DD amazingly closed down without a mention of the incident, as its horrifying rule book precluded the extension of its transmission over the death of an opposition leader, which Gandhi then was.

However it was only with the advent of Zee TV, a Hindi general entertainment channel in October 1992, that cable TV began expanding explosively. For legions of Indians, the glamorous cosmos of Indian cinema had suddenly been pitchforked from theatres

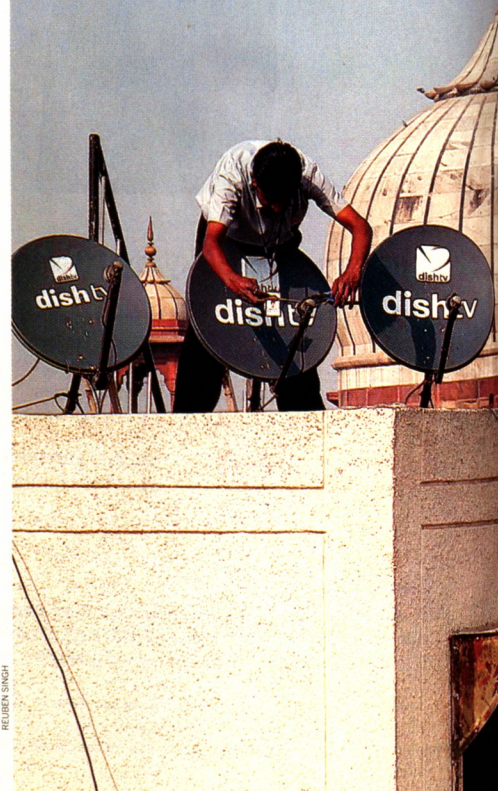
**STAR WARS: A technician at work in Old Delhi**

**68 m**  
households in  
India have  
access to satellite  
and cable television

**54 m**  
television households  
all over India have  
access to only  
terrestrial channels

# A dish FETISH

From a garage industry to a nationwide attack on Doordarshan's monopoly, a distant war in the Middle East changed forever India's relationship with its tv set



REUBEN SINGH